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FinTech Bootcamp Report

1. Introduction

The FinTech Bootcamp really changed how we see the industry. Before attending, we mostly thought of FinTech as digital banking, cryptocurrencies, and shaking up traditional banks. But after the sessions, discussions, and assignments, our view grew much broader.

We now see that FinTech is more than just new technology or faster services. It is an evolving system shaped by trust, integration, regulation, and accessibility (Sarah, Roman, Ingrid, Lander, Charlotte).

2. Rethinking Finance and FinTech

At first, we thought FinTech was mostly about making banking better or replacing old systems. We also believed that blockchain and cryptocurrencies would mostly work outside of traditional finance (Sarah, Lander).

However, we learned that:

- FinTech innovations are often integrated into existing financial systems rather than replacing them (Sarah, Ingrid)
- Banks are actively exploring blockchain and crypto-related technologies such as tokenisation and crypto trading services (Lander)
- Finance is shifting toward a connected ecosystem of platforms and institutions (Roman, Ingrid)

We also took time to think critically about these changes. Blockchain started as a decentralised alternative to traditional finance, but as more institutions adopt it, we wonder whether this undermines its original purpose (Lander).

3. Trust as the Core of Finance

A key insight across all reflections was that trust is the foundation of financial systems:

- The core asset of banks is trust rather than infrastructure or technology (Roman)
- Even decentralised systems still rely on institutions for security, compliance, and reliability (Ingrid)
- FinTech innovations must maintain trust to be adopted (Sarah)

This helped us realize that banks are not going away. Instead, they are becoming trusted providers of infrastructure in a larger financial system.

4. Key Learnings and Innovations

4.1 Embedded Finance and Ecosystems

We learned that finance is now part of many everyday digital platforms:

- Banking is now part of the customer journey rather than a final destination (Ingrid)
- Financial services are integrated into non-financial platforms (Roman)
- Finance is turning into a background system that people use without noticing (Sarah, Roman)

4.2 Banking-as-a-Service

We discovered that:

- Financial services can be built rapidly using modular API-based systems (Roman)
- Non-bank companies can offer financial products (Roman)
- This makes it easier for new companies to enter the market and changes how businesses compete.

We found this change especially surprising.

4.3 Tokenisation, Crypto, and Fractional Finance

We looked into tokenisation and what it could mean for finance:

- Assets can be divided into digital shares, enabling fractional ownership (Ingrid, Charlotte)
- This lowers entry barriers and increases accessibility (Sarah, Charlotte)
- Tokenisation improves liquidity and flexibility (Ingrid)

At the same time, we reflected critically on crypto:

- Blockchain was originally created to avoid centralised control and increase trust through decentralisation (Lander)
- The growing involvement of banks in crypto-related services represents a shift toward institutionalisation (Lander)

This creates a real conflict between the original idea of decentralization and how finance is now becoming more integrated.

4.4 Stablecoins and Cross-Border Payments

We learned that:

- Stablecoins enable faster and cheaper global transactions (Ingrid)
- They challenge traditional systems such as SWIFT (Ingrid)
- They show the challenges that come up between new ideas and existing rules.

4.5 Artificial Intelligence in Finance

We learned a lot about how AI is changing finance:

- AI can automate processes, improve decision-making, and reduce fraud (Sarah)
- AI agents and chatbots are increasingly used in banking (Sarah, Lander)
- AI can simplify transactions through fewer steps or even voice commands (Lander)

But we also noticed an important trade-off:

- Customers value both control and convenience, meaning banks must balance security with ease of use (Lander)

5. Regulation and Its Role

The way we think about regulation changed during the bootcamp:

- Regulation ensures trust, transparency, and security (Sarah, Ingrid)
- It shapes how innovation is developed and implemented (Ingrid)

We also learned that FinTech companies face a dual regulatory burden:

- Financial regulations
- AI-specific regulations, such as the EU AI Act

This overlap can slow down innovation because companies have to spend a lot on compliance before launching products (Lander). Still, it shows why responsible innovation matters, especially in risky financial areas.

6. Financial Inclusion and the Human Side of FinTech

One of the biggest lessons for us was seeing the human side of FinTech:

- Financial services can reach previously excluded populations (Sarah, Charlotte)
- Fractional finance allows participation with very small amounts of capital (Charlotte)
- Services like Nickel provide access to a first bank account and financial dignity (Charlotte)

We also explored broader societal impact:

- Financial tools can support smallholder farmers and food security (Roman, Charlotte)
- There is a significant funding gap in agricultural finance (Roman)
- FinTech can enable micro-insurance and highly granular financial services (Charlotte)

A particularly powerful realisation was that access to financial services can:

- Enable economic independence, especially for vulnerable groups (Charlotte)
- Act as a tool against economic exclusion and inequality.

This changed how we think, moving our focus from just technology to its real-world impact and how accessible it is.

7. Strategic Importance of Financial Systems

We also saw that finance has a strategic side:

- Payment systems reflect dependency and control over infrastructure (Roman)
- There is growing interest in building independent financial systems.
- Financial infrastructure is linked to economic and digital sovereignty.

8. Challenges of Implementation

By doing hands-on exercises, we learned that:

- Digital transformation is difficult to implement (Ingrid)
- Success depends on team alignment and execution (Ingrid)
- Strong ideas alone are not sufficient without proper coordination

9. Conclusion

Looking back, we now see that FinTech is not just about being faster, cheaper, or more digital. It is really about changing how financial systems work at a basic level.

We conclude that:

- Finance is becoming embedded, programmable, and platform-based (Sarah, Roman, Ingrid)
- Banks remain essential as providers of trust and infrastructure (Roman, Ingrid)
- Innovation must operate within ecosystems shaped by regulation, collaboration, and user needs (Sarah, Lander)
- FinTech has the potential to create not only efficiency, but also meaningful social impact (Charlotte)

In the end, the future of finance is not about getting rid of old systems, but about redesigning them to work in a more connected, inclusive, and digital world.